

## Summary of The King's Speech (State Opening of Parliament 13<sup>th</sup> May 2026)

### Employability and skills implications for England

The King's Speech set out the Government's legislative programme for the new parliamentary session, with a strong emphasis on economic security, public service reform, opportunity, infrastructure, vocational education, apprenticeships, youth unemployment and welfare-to-work reform. The most directly relevant section for employability and skills was the commitment that young people should not be held back by poverty, SEND, or "a lack of respect for vocational education", alongside continued investment in apprenticeships and measures to tackle youth unemployment.

#### 1. Apprenticeships and vocational education were explicitly referenced

The speech directly stated that ministers would "continue to invest in apprenticeships" and tackle youth unemployment. This is important because it places apprenticeships within the Government's wider economic security and opportunity agenda, rather than treating them purely as an education route.

For the employability and skills sector, the key point is that apprenticeships are likely to remain central to the Government's productivity, youth employment and progression narrative. However, the speech itself did not set out detailed changes to apprenticeship funding, levy reform, eligibility, employer incentives or provider accountability.

#### 2. Youth unemployment remains a clear policy priority

The reference to "measures that tackle youth unemployment" is highly relevant to programmes such as Youth Guarantee Trailblazers, local youth employment partnerships, careers support, NEET interventions and place-based employability models.

The framing suggests continued policy interest in early intervention, transition support, employer engagement and localised youth pathways, especially where young people face multiple barriers to work. The speech did not appear to announce a new standalone youth employment bill, but it does create a policy platform for further announcements through departmental plans, funding settlements or responses to reviews.

#### 3. Education for All Bill: SEND, standards and inclusion

A major education measure was the proposed Education for All Bill, intended to raise school standards and introduce "generational reforms" to the SEND system. □ FE

Week reports that the Bill will legislate for SEND reform and that policy notes describe an ambition for early access to support closer to home, with schools, nurseries and colleges expected to deliver more inclusive provision.

For employability and skills, this matters because SEND reform has a direct line into post-16 transitions, supported internships, preparation for adulthood, careers guidance, college capacity, EHCP transitions, and employment outcomes for young people with additional needs. The risk is that reforms focused on school standards and system efficiency may not automatically translate into stronger employment pathways unless colleges, employers, local authorities and supported employment providers are properly built into delivery.

#### **4. Welfare reform and work: Milburn and Timms Reviews**

The speech confirmed that the Government will respond to the Milburn Review and the Timms Review and continue reforming welfare so that young and disabled people can “flourish in work”.

This is one of the most important employability signals. It points to further policy development around economic inactivity, disability employment, youth transitions, welfare conditionality, employment support and the relationship between benefits, health and work. The Guardian noted that, despite this commitment, the speech did not include a standalone welfare reform bill, with ministers expected to respond to review findings later.

#### **5. Economic security, growth and employment**

The speech framed economic security around raising living standards, public investment, private investment, business partnership, higher growth and a “fair deal for working people”.

This is pertinent because employability and skills are being positioned as part of a broader growth model: improving productivity, connecting people to opportunity, supporting key sectors, and aligning training with local labour market demand. The specific links to infrastructure, steel, rail, aviation and regulation also suggest opportunities for skills planning around construction, engineering, manufacturing, green infrastructure, logistics, transport and advanced industries.

#### **6. Infrastructure and industrial policy create skills demand**

The speech included proposed legislation for airport expansion, the Lower Thames Crossing, Northern Powerhouse Rail, Great British Railways, and safeguarding domestic steel production.

For England’s skills system, this creates a strong argument for local and regional skills plans that connect capital investment to jobs, apprenticeships, pre-employment

training, technical education, employer academies and supply-chain workforce development. The key issue will be whether these major infrastructure commitments are accompanied by enforceable skills, social value and local employment requirements.

## 7. Small business and employer engagement

The proposed Small Business Protections (Late Payments) Bill and Regulating for Growth Bill are not skills bills, but they are relevant to employer engagement. The speech said the Government would tackle late payments and reduce unnecessary regulation through innovation.

For employability programmes, particularly those working with SMEs, this matters because cashflow, administrative burden and business confidence often shape whether employers can offer placements, interviews, apprenticeships or entry-level jobs. A stronger SME environment could support employer participation, but employability providers will still need practical incentives, brokerage and post-placement support.

## Strategic read-across for employability and skills

The speech does not radically rewrite the skills landscape, but it reinforces five clear priorities:

- Youth employment and apprenticeships remain central to the Government's opportunity agenda.
- SEND and inclusion will become a major reform area, with implications for colleges, local authorities, careers services and supported employment.
- Welfare-to-work reform is likely to return through the Government's response to the Milburn and Timms Reviews, rather than through an immediate standalone bill.
- Infrastructure and industrial strategy will increase demand for technical skills, local labour market planning and employer-led pipelines.
- Place-based delivery will be important, because the policies cut across schools, colleges, local authorities, devolved bodies, employers, health, welfare and transport.

## Summary

For the employability and skills sector in England, the King's Speech signals continuity rather than surprise: apprenticeships, youth unemployment, SEND reform, welfare-to-work and economic inactivity remain firmly on the policy agenda. The opportunity now is to ensure that national legislation is translated into practical local delivery models: integrated youth support, stronger employer brokerage, inclusive pathways for disabled young people and adults, and skills pipelines linked to real labour market demand